

Modernism

Modernism emerged in both Europe and the United States at the beginning of the 20th century, although neither the timing nor the term is definitive. Since the late 19th century there had been numerous attempts to assimilate modern technology into a new architectural style to embrace the new century, with skyscrapers – one of modernism's icons – appearing in the United States as early as the 1880s.

More a philosophy than a style, modernism in architecture emerged from an analytical approach that allowed the function of a building to dictate its form. Modernism rejected historical precedent and ornament, and favoured the rational use of 'new' materials, including steel, aluminium and concrete, often with large expanses of glass. The First World War interrupted most new developments, and although a few modernist buildings appeared before 1914, the movement really only gathered momentum after 1918. Overall, modernism wrought a profound transformation upon architecture.

